Yet public engagement with the IMF often comes at a steep political cost. Given these dynamics, populist leaders are expected to favor more discreet methods of interaction with the IMF, avoiding public scrutiny while still reaping some of the institution's benefits. One key avenue for covert IMF engagement is through executive board meetings, where member states influence the organization's policies and programs. A crucial mechanism for shaping discussions at these meetings is the submission of pre-meeting written statements, known as "Grays." These documents, filed by executive directors, outline countries' stances on issues ranging from conditionality and lending to institutional reforms. Grays are housed in the IMF's archives and declassified after three to five years, making them an ideal proxy for private participation.

Grays are meaningful: They reflect careful deliberation and encapsulate the official positions of member states. Executive directors, who represent their home governments, craft these statements in consultation with national authorities. Deviations from a government's stance can lead to tensions or even recalls, ensuring that Grays align closely with state preferences. Additional details and analysis can be found in Carnegie, Clark, and Kaya (2024).

TABLE 6.1. Illustrative Grays

Country	Date	Topic	Representative detail from Gray
Argentina	2/10/10	The Fund's mandate in post–2008 crisis period	"The Fund must therefore play a bolder role in fostering a fundamental change in the form and degree of international cooperation."
China	7/27/95	Exchange-rate restrictions	"We do understand that it is necessary to consider an enlargement of the GAB [General Agreements to Borrow] in order for the Fund to play an effective role in assisting its member countries in financial emergencies."